

Vienna Sausage Stand Gets UNESCO Recognition

A popular kind of sausage stand in Vienna, Austria has been recognized by the United Nations for its cultural value.

The street stands – called “Würstelstands” in German – are a famous part of the Austrian capital’s history. In addition to selling food, they are known for being a place where many different kinds of people can come together to eat and spend social time.

UNESCO is the United Nations’ Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. It seeks to recognize and help save cultural treasures and traditions around the world.

Vienna’s Würstelstands were recently added to a list of the country’s “intangible cultural heritage.” The Austrian UNESCO Commission oversees the list.

Hot sausages get prepared at a traditional sausage stand (Wuerstelstand), which are named as intangible cultural heritage by the Austrian UNESCO Commission, in Vienna, Austria, Thursday, Nov. 28, 2024. (AP Photo/Heinz-Peter Bader)

Among other things on the list are Vienna’s traditional wine establishments – called “Heurigen” – which were recognized in 2019. In addition, the city’s famous coffee house culture was honored in 2011.

The Associated Press reports the history of Würstelstands goes back generations. And they are known for much more than the tasty sausages they serve. They have been bringing people of many different backgrounds together for many years. The stands have also developed some of their own terms.

These include the “Haasse,” a special kind of boiled sausage. Another unusual stand offering is known as the “Käsekrainer” – a smoked creation filled with cheese. And there is “Oaschpfeiferl,” a spicy peperoni version, as well as the pickled “Krokodü.”

Customers eat hot sausages at a traditional sausage stand (Wuerstelstand), which are named as intangible cultural heritage by the Austrian UNESCO Commission, in Vienna, Austria, Thursday, Nov. 28, 2024. (AP Photo/Heinz-Peter Bader)

Josef Bitzinger runs the Bitzinger Würstelstand. He told the AP that sausage stands have a long history in Vienna." His stand enjoys a favorable spot, next to the city’s Albertina museum and just behind the Vienna State Opera.

“Originally it was just a bucket with hot water in which the sausages used to swim,” Bitzinger said. He added that the stands began with small vehicles pulled by dogs or horses. Later, they

were transported by cars or big trucks.

The tradition of Würstelstand goes back to the pre-World War I days of the Austro-Hungarian Empire. At that time, former soldiers set up movable cooking shops to make a living.

The city's longest-serving stand in a fixed spot is Würstelstand Leo. It has been serving up sausages since 1928. The stands started to develop quickly in 1969, when the government decided to begin approving fixed stands.

A vendor serves a hot dog at a traditional sausage stand (Wuerstelstand), which are named as intangible cultural heritage by the Austrian UNESCO Commission, in Vienna, Austria, Thursday, Nov. 28, 2024. (AP Photo/Heinz-Peter Bader)

Vienna's mayor, Michael Ludwig, said he thinks the UNESCO recognition "honors the tradition, the hospitality and the diversity of our city." He added that the stands remain a big part of the city's culture.

Bitzinger said he and other owners had long campaigned for the UNESCO recognition. "The special thing about it is that it's a form of gastronomy everybody can afford."

Bitzinger added, "Here the general director and, during the opera ball, a celebrity stands next to a worker and the street sweeper who just finished cleaning the street. That unites people."

I'm Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press reported this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

intangible - adj. ที่จับต้องไม่ได้, ที่เป็นนามธรรม (มีอยู่จริงแต่ยากจะอธิบายหรือพิสูจน์)

pickled - adj. ที่ถูกดอง, ที่ถูกหมัก (ในน้ำส้มสายชูหรือน้ำเกลือ)

heritage - n. มรดก, มรดกทางวัฒนธรรม (สิ่งก่อสร้าง ภาพวาด ขนบธรรมเนียม ฯลฯ ที่มีมานานและสำคัญต่อวัฒนธรรมหรือสังคม)

original - adj. ดั้งเดิม, แรกเริ่ม (มีมาตั้งแต่ต้น)

hospitality - n. การต้อนรับ, อضيวยไมตรี (อาหาร เครื่องดื่ม และความบันเทิงที่องค์กรหรือธุรกิจจัดหาให้)

diversity - n. ความหลากหลาย (ข้อเท็จจริงที่ว่ามีสิ่งของหรือผู้คนหลายประเภทที่รวมอยู่ในบางสิ่ง)

gastronomy - n. ศาสตร์การทำอาหาร, การทำอาหารชั้นสูง (ศิลปะและความรู้ที่ใช้ในการเตรียมและรับประทานอาหารอร่อย)

afford - v. สามารถจ่ายได้, มีกำลังซื้อ (สามารถชำระค่าบางสิ่งได้)

celebrity - n. ผู้มีชื่อเสียง, ดารา (บุคคลที่มีชื่อเสียง)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

- 1. What has been recognized by the United Nations for its cultural value in Vienna, Austria?**
 - A. A specific type of traditional Austrian bread.
 - B. The city's famous coffee house culture.
 - C. A popular kind of sausage stand.
 - D. The historical architecture of Vienna.

- 2. Besides selling food, what is another significant role of Würstelstands in Vienna, according to the article?**
 - A. Providing a venue for art exhibitions.
 - B. Serving as a place for diverse people to socialize.
 - C. Offering guided tours of the city's history.
 - D. Functioning as local information centers.

- 3. What is the primary objective of UNESCO, as stated in the text?**
 - A. To fund scientific research globally.
 - B. To promote educational reforms worldwide.
 - C. To recognize and preserve cultural heritage and traditions.
 - D. To organize international cultural festivals.

- 4. What specific status were Vienna's Würstelstands recently granted by the Austrian UNESCO Commission?**
 - A. A national culinary landmark.
 - B. A world heritage site.
 - C. An intangible cultural heritage.
 - D. A protected historical monument.

- 5. According to the image caption in paragraph 6, which entity named the Würstelstands as intangible cultural heritage?**
 - A. The United Nations Headquarters.
 - B. The Austrian UNESCO Commission.
 - C. The Vienna City Council.
 - D. The European Union.

- 6. Besides Würstelstands, what other Viennese traditions have received cultural recognition, according to the article?**

- A. The Spanish Riding School and classical music concerts.
- B. Traditional wine establishments and coffee house culture.
- C. The annual New Year's Concert and the Prater amusement park.
- D. Imperial palaces and historic city squares.

7. What does the Associated Press report about the history of Würstelstands?

- A. They are a modern invention from the late 20th century.
- B. Their history dates back several generations.
- C. They were first established during the post-World War II era.
- D. The exact origins of Würstelstands are unknown.

8. Which of the following sausage types is NOT specifically mentioned as an offering at Würstelstands in paragraph 9?

- A. Haasse
- B. Käsekrainer
- C. Weißwurst
- D. Krokodü

9. Where is Josef Bitzinger's Würstelstand, the Bitzinger Würstelstand, located?

- A. In the heart of Vienna's financial district.
- B. Next to the Albertina museum and behind the Vienna State Opera.
- C. Along the historic Ringstrasse.
- D. Inside a famous shopping mall.

10. How did Würstelstands originally operate, according to Josef Bitzinger?

- A. As stationary brick-and-mortar restaurants.
- B. With sausages in hot water buckets, transported by animal-drawn vehicles.
- C. Using large, modern food trucks.
- D. As small, fixed market stalls from the beginning.

11. When did the tradition of Würstelstands begin, and who were some of their early operators?

- A. After World War II, run by returning war veterans.
- B. Before World War I, during the Austro-Hungarian Empire, operated by former soldiers.
- C. In the mid-19th century, started by farmers selling their produce.
- D. During the Cold War era, initiated by local entrepreneurs.

12. What significant change occurred in 1969 regarding Würstelstands?

- A. Würstelstand Leo opened its doors for the first time.
- B. The government began approving fixed locations for the stands.
- C. They were officially recognized as a cultural heritage.
- D. International tourists started flocking to them.

13. According to Vienna's Mayor Michael Ludwig, what aspects of the city does the UNESCO recognition honor?

- A. The city's economic prosperity and technological advancement.
- B. Its tradition, hospitality, and diversity.
- C. The efficiency of its public transportation system.
- D. The innovation of its modern culinary scene.

14. What does Josef Bitzinger highlight as a unique characteristic of Würstelstands regarding their gastronomy?

- A. Their exclusive menu for high-ranking officials.
- B. Their innovative and experimental cooking techniques.
- C. Their affordability, making it accessible to everyone.
- D. Their focus on organic and locally sourced ingredients.

15. In Bitzinger's view, what is the unifying effect of Würstelstands, as described in paragraph 18?

- A. They encourage people to learn German culinary traditions.
- B. They bring together people from different social classes and professions.
- C. They serve as a platform for political debates and discussions.
- D. They promote physical activity through walking to the stands.